

THE RIGHT PRESCRIPTION

A large number of doctors are enrolling in management schools to take advantage of opportunities offered by the fast-growing healthcare industry for medical specialists

■ By Nandini Vaish

At Kadavanthara in Kochi, Biju Mohandas, India business manager for the Acumen (venture) Fund, is busy wrapping up a Rs 4.4-crore deal with AyurVAID Hospitals, to set up a chain of ayurvedic hospitals across the country. The due diligence checklist that he uses includes crucial aspects related to hospi-

number of doctors who have a nontraditional resume. A five-year stint in the Indian Army, where he was involved with a lot of managerial and administrative work, in addition to clinical duties, made this graduate of the MS Ramaiah Dental College, Bangalore, realise that he "would rather be involved in healthcare management, than sit in a clinic all day long and see patients". The same goes for Dr Rakesh Kapur, a

process shorter and a more meaningful experience. Today as a manager with Ernst & Young's (E&Y) healthcare advisory practice, he is working on it—advising hospitals on their strategy as well as operations.

Meet the new business-minded doctors. In a country where doctors are treated like demi-gods, many young people are hanging up their stethoscopes for an MBA degree, thanks to the



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

ASHIMA SARKAR, 28
ASSISTANT MANAGER, PRE-SALES,
FIRSTSOURCE

Left ayurvedic practice, against her parents' wishes. "If I could make it to a good B-school, my career would be set."



A PRADHANNAH NAQ

tal management and medical protocol. Most of these are issues which only either a doctor or someone who has experience in managing hospitals can address. That's not a problem for Mohandas—who joined the venture capital firm just about a year back—as he is a qualified doctor. And it is for this very reason that he was picked for the job—combining a doctor's knowledge with the business and financial acumen of a management professional.

Mohandas received an MBA from the Indian School of Business (ISB) in Hyderabad and is one among a growing

Delhi-based neurologist. After completing his MBBS from the DJ Medical College in Pune, Kapur worked in Delhi's Apollo Hospital. He soon quit to run his own 100-bed hospital in the capital's Vasant Kunj area which he took on lease. Eighteen months later, he too found himself enrolled at the ISB. Says Kapur, "I realised that a patient ends up spending less than 10-15 minutes with a doctor. The rest of the time goes in the check-in, check-out process, which in most hospitals can take up to 2.5 hours." In a sector where emotions run very high, Kapur wanted to make the

demands of the rapidly-growing healthcare industry. Doctor-MBAs are not only making way into hospital management, health insurance, pharmaceuticals, biotechnology, clinical research and medical devices, but also into advertising (healthcare), corporate banking (lending for SMEs), finance (equity research or private equity) as well as IT/ITES companies where they can fit into consulting, marketing, business development or strategy roles.

Today, almost all major B-schools are attracting doctors. At ISB this year, at least 13 in a batch of 442 students